

Handout: *Jennifer McKitrick, “A Case for Extrinsic Dispositions”*

The Problem

Philosophers have widely assumed what McKitrick calls the **Intrinsic Dispositions Thesis**:

Necessarily, perfect intrinsic duplicates share all dispositions (given fixed laws of nature). (pp. 155–156)

This assumption underwrites major positions in:

- **Metaphysics** (relation between dispositions and causal bases)
- **Philosophy of mind** (e.g., internalism vs. externalism)

But the problem:

There are *no good arguments* for this thesis, and it conflicts with intuitive and scientific examples.

The Solution

McKitrick defends the **Extrinsic Dispositions Thesis**:

Some dispositions are extrinsic—perfect duplicates can differ in their dispositions even with identical intrinsic properties and fixed laws. (p. 155)

Her strategy:

1. Provide a **minimal characterization of dispositions**
 2. Clarify **intrinsic vs. extrinsic properties**
 3. Offer **counterexamples** (extrinsic dispositions)
 4. Defuse three major objections
 5. Critique arguments for intrinsicness
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I. Marks of Dispositionality (pp. 156–158)

Rather than a controversial analysis, McKittrick gives **widely accepted** “marks” of dispositions.

Core Features

A property is *probably dispositional* if it has:

- **Manifestation**
 - A characteristic outcome (e.g., fragility → breaking)
- **Circumstances of manifestation**
 - Conditions triggering the manifestation (e.g., being struck)
- **Counterfactual connection**
 - If in C, then M would occur
 - (“If dropped, it would break”)
- **Dispositional locution**
 - Expressible as: “*the disposition to M in C*”

These marks function as **heuristics**, not strict criteria. (p. 158)

Key Philosophical Context

- Connects to debates over **conditional analyses of dispositions**
 - Reflects a **broad consensus** across figures like Ryle, Armstrong, Lewis
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II. Intrinsic vs. Extrinsic Properties (pp. 158–159)

Intrinsic Properties

- Depend *only* on the object itself
- Shared by **perfect duplicates**

Extrinsic Properties

- Depend on **relations to the environment**
- Can differ between duplicates

Important qualification:

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- McKitrick fixes **laws of nature** to avoid trivializing extrinsicity
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III. The Case: Examples of Extrinsic Dispositions (pp. 159–163)

McKitrick's central argumentative move:

Show that some properties satisfying the **marks of dispositionality** are **extrinsic**

A. The Key and the Door (p. 159)

- A key has:
 - **Disposition:** to open *this door*
 - **Manifestation:** door opening
 - **Trigger:** insertion and turning

Crucial point:

- Change the lock and the key loses the disposition
- No intrinsic change to the key

The disposition depends on environment

B. Weight (pp. 159–160)

- Defined dispositionally:
 - *Disposition to register n on a scale in a local gravitational field*

Contrast:

- **Mass** = intrinsic
- **Weight** = varies with environment

Perfect duplicates (Earth vs. Moon) differ in weight

Weight is an extrinsic disposition

C. Context-Sensitive Dispositions (pp. 160–161)

Example:

- Water dissolving “the contents of my pocket”

Key issue:

- Rigid vs. non-rigid designation

If non-rigid:

- Depends on what’s in the pocket (i.e. is extrinsic)
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D. Vulnerability (p. 161)

- Disposition to suffer harm under attack

Example:

- City protected by external defense system

Remove defense:

- Vulnerability changes
- No intrinsic change to city

Extrinsic disposition

E. Visibility (pp. 161–163)

Two notions:

- **Philosophical visibility** (ideal conditions)
- **Ordinary visibility** (actual conditions)

McKittrick focuses on the latter:

- Depends on lighting, obstructions, etc.

Object can become invisible without intrinsic change

Visibility is extrinsic

F. Recognizability (p. 163)

- Bill Clinton is recognizable

But:

- Only because of **social environment**

Duplicate in different world:

- Not recognizable

Socially-dependent dispositions are extrinsic

IV. Objection 1: Relational Specification (pp. 163–167)

The Objection

- These are merely **relationally specified intrinsic properties**
- Dispositions are always described using external references

McKitrick's Response

- **Distinction:**
 - *Relational specification ≠ extrinsic property*
- Even if context helps specify meaning:
 - The **property itself** can still depend on environment

If the *same property* varies across environments, it is genuinely extrinsic.

V. Objection 2: Underlying Intrinsic Bases (pp. 167–168)

The Objection

- Extrinsic dispositions are:
 - **Derived from intrinsic ones**
 - Not fundamental

Response

- Even if derivative:
 - They are still **real dispositions**

“You cannot say Fs are derived from Gs unless there are some Fs.” (p. 167)

- Also:
 - Extrinsic dispositions are often **more explanatorily relevant**
 - (e.g., key opening *this* door)
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VI. Objection 3: Natural Properties (pp. 168–170)

The Objection

- Extrinsic dispositions are:
 - “gerrymandered”
 - Not **natural properties**

Response

1. **Some are ordinary predicates**
 - Vulnerable, visible, recognizable
2. **Not all dispositions are natural**
 - Even intrinsic ones may be disjunctive
3. **Abundance of properties**
 - (Lewis-inspired view)

There are far more dispositions than those linguistically or scientifically privileged.

VII. Arguments for Intrinsic Dispositions (pp. 170–173)

A. Conceptual Argument

Claim:

- “Disposition” conceptually implies intrinsic structure

Reply:

- Etymology is irrelevant
 - Philosophical usage is broader
 - Standard accounts (Ryle, Goodman) do not support this
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B. Armstrong’s Argument

Structure:

- Manifestations depend on:
 - Cause + circumstances + intrinsic nature

Therefore dispositions must be intrinsic

McKittrick’s critique:

- **Question-begging:** assumes only intrinsic properties matter
- **Hasty generalization:** based on limited examples (e.g., fragility)

Counterexamples (e.g., recognizability) clearly involve extrinsic factors.
